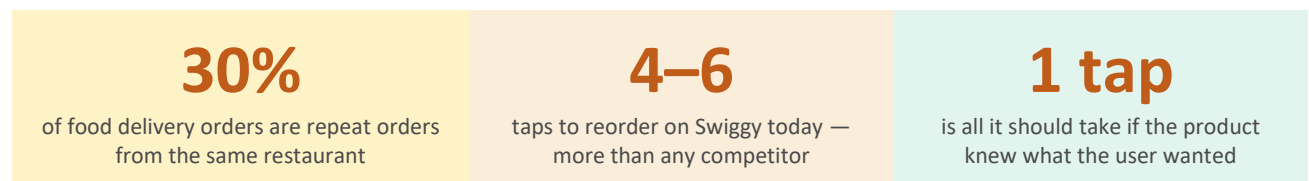


Why Swiggy makes reordering harder than it should be

A product case study · Aryan Srivastava · April 2025

This is a case study on a small UX problem that costs Swiggy a measurable number of repeat orders every day. It's not a dramatic flaw. It's the kind of thing that's easy to miss when you're building fast but once you see it, you can't unsee it.

I spent time using Swiggy as a regular user, tracking my own behaviour, and reading through Play Store and App Store reviews to understand what real users are experiencing. The problem I found isn't about payment, delivery speed, or customer support. It's about what happens when someone tries to reorder something they've had before.



What made me look at this

I ordered the same meal chicken biryani from the same restaurant four times in two months. Each time I went through the exact same process: open Swiggy, search for the restaurant, scroll through the menu, find the right item, add it to cart, checkout. The whole thing took 3–4 minutes even though the decision was made the moment I opened the app.

Swiggy does have a reorder feature. It exists. There's a 'Reorder' button in the order history section. But to get to it you have to: tap the profile icon, tap 'Orders', scroll through past orders to find the right one, and then tap 'Reorder'. If your cart isn't empty which it often isn't if you abandoned a previous session you get a dialog asking whether to clear the cart or merge items. By the time you've navigated all of that, you've done almost as much work as starting from scratch.

That experience where the product technically has the feature but makes it more effort than it's worth is the problem.

The reorder feature exists. But the effort to use it is high enough that most users just restart from scratch which means Swiggy is leaving repeat order conversions on the table every day.

What the problem actually is

The core issue isn't the existence of the reorder button. It's where it lives and how much friction surrounds it.

Problem 1 — Reorder is buried three taps deep

On the home screen, Swiggy shows you a carousel of restaurants, a search bar, and promotional banners. What it doesn't show you unless you've ordered very recently and it appears in a small 'Rapid Reorder' strip is your order history. The reorder flow requires you to navigate away from the home screen entirely, which breaks the mental model of 'I want to eat the same thing I had last week.'

Zomato handles this differently. Their home screen has a persistent 'Order Again' section that shows your three most recent distinct orders restaurant name, items, and a one-tap reorder button right on the home screen, visible without scrolling. It's not perfect but the discoverability is significantly better.

Problem 2 — The cart conflict dialog breaks momentum

When a user taps Reorder and has an existing item in their cart, Swiggy shows a modal: 'You have items in your cart from [restaurant]. Would you like to replace them or add to your cart?' This sounds reasonable in isolation. In practice, it stops a user who had already decided what they wanted and forces a decision they weren't expecting. A good number of those users close the dialog, get distracted, and don't complete the order.

The better behaviour: if the user is reordering from the same restaurant as the existing cart, merge automatically. If from a different restaurant, replace automatically with a small undo snackbar. Eliminate the decision point entirely.

Problem 3 — Partial availability isn't handled gracefully

If one item from a previous order is unavailable today the restaurant removed it, it's sold out, or it's not available at this hour Swiggy's current behaviour is to show an error after you've already tapped Reorder. You go through the flow, tap the button, and then find out mid-process that something doesn't work. The reorder flow should check availability before surfacing the option, or should clearly show which items will be added and which won't before the user commits.

What users are saying

I went through Play Store and App Store reviews filtering for 'reorder' and 'order again' mentions. A few things came up repeatedly.

- Several users mentioned tapping Reorder and landing on a version of the menu where items had changed price or weren't available, without any warning before completing the reorder
- Multiple reviews mentioned the cart conflict dialog specifically phrases like 'annoying popup' and 'have to keep clearing my cart' appear across different reviews
- A common workaround pattern: users bookmarking specific items or using the search function to find the exact restaurant by name rather than using the reorder feature at all which means they've given up on the native flow
- The 'Rapid Reorder' feature that appears on the home screen after a recent order was described positively by the few users who mentioned it suggesting the concept is right but the execution doesn't go far enough

Users who found a workaround aren't happy users. They're users who stopped trusting the product to solve the problem natively and figured out how to route around it.

What I'd change

Three changes, in order of effort and impact.

Change 1 — Surface reorder on the home screen, always

The home screen should have a permanent 'Order Again' section not a carousel, not buried showing the user's last three distinct restaurant orders with a one-tap reorder option. Not just recent orders from the past 24 hours. Your last three orders, whenever they were. This is the first thing many users want when they open the food delivery app with intent to eat something specific.

This is a home screen real estate decision and it will require deprioritising something else — probably one promotional banner. The trade-off is worth it. A repeat order has a near-zero customer acquisition cost and high likelihood of completion. A promotional banner converts cold.

Change 2 — Eliminate the cart conflict dialog

Same restaurant as current cart: merge items automatically. Different restaurant: replace cart with a 5-second undo snackbar at the bottom of the screen. No modal. No decision point. The user who is reordering has already decided what they want don't introduce friction at the exact moment their intent is highest.

The undo snackbar handles the edge case where someone accidentally taps Reorder. It's less disruptive than a modal and requires less cognitive effort from the user.

Change 3 — Availability check before the user taps Reorder

Before showing the Reorder button on any past order, check whether the restaurant is currently open and whether the items in that order are currently available. If the restaurant is closed, show 'Available from 12pm' instead of the Reorder button. If some items are unavailable, show 'Reorder (2 of 3 items available)' so the user knows what they're getting before they tap.

This eliminates the worst version of the current experience tapping Reorder with confidence and hitting an error halfway through. Surfacing the information before the tap means the user can make a real decision rather than being surprised.

How I'd know if it worked

Primary metric — Reorder conversion rate

Of all users who see the Reorder option, what percentage complete the order? This is the direct measure of whether the changes are working. A lift here means the UX improvements translated into actual orders, not just better ratings. I'd expect a 20–30% lift from changes 1 and 2 alone, based on the nature of the friction being removed.

Secondary metric — Time to order completion for repeat users

How long does it take from app open to order placed for users who are reordering? This should drop significantly if the home screen section is working — users who know what they want should be completing orders in under 90 seconds, not 3–4 minutes.

Guardrail — Cart abandonment rate

Change 2 eliminates the cart conflict dialog. The risk is that some users who would have kept their original cart now accidentally replace it. If cart abandonment goes up after the change measured as users who reach checkout and drop off it suggests the undo snackbar isn't working well enough as a safety net.

Trade-offs I thought about

Why not just make the reorder button more prominent in the existing location?

I considered this. Making the button bigger or adding an entry point in the bottom navigation bar would be a lower-effort change. The problem is that it doesn't solve the discovery problem users who don't think to look in 'Orders' won't find it regardless of how prominent it is within that flow. The home screen placement works because it meets the user at the moment of intent, not after they've already had to navigate somewhere.

Wouldn't auto-replacing the cart frustrate users who put effort into building it?

Possibly, in some cases. But the user who taps Reorder has expressed a clear, specific intent. The user who built a cart and then opened the app again to reorder something else from a different restaurant is a more complicated edge case. The undo snackbar handles it. The majority of users who hit the cart conflict dialog today don't want a dialog they want the food.

Is this actually a big problem for Swiggy or just a minor annoyance?

Minor annoyances at scale are big problems. If 30% of orders are repeats, and even 10% of those reorder attempts hit friction that causes abandonment, that's a meaningful number of lost orders per day. At Swiggy's GMV, 'minor' UX friction in a high-frequency flow translates to real revenue left uncaptured. That's the business case.

What I took away from this

The thing I found most interesting about this problem isn't the specific fix the fix is relatively obvious once you've identified the problem. The more interesting question is why it hasn't been fixed yet.

My guess: the reorder flow was built as a utility feature, not as a core conversion path. It lives in the profile section because that's where 'your stuff' lives. Nobody made the explicit decision to treat reordering as a primary use case that deserves home screen real estate. That's a prioritisation and strategy question more than a design question.

A PM's job in this situation isn't just to identify the UX problem. It's to make the argument that repeat order conversion is a core metric worth protecting, that the reorder flow is a critical path for that metric, and that the friction in that path has a measurable cost. Once you frame it that way, the fix becomes easier to prioritise.